

Mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of Congo

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summary

Mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) refers to the use of mobile-enabled wallets and payment services to send, receive, and spend money in a largely cash-reliant economy. Despite high mobile phone penetration and growing digital payment activity, the DRC remains in the early stages of formal financial inclusion, with mobile money seen as a key pathway to broaden access to payments, remittances, and basic financial services across urban and rural communities [\[1\]\[2\]](#).

The topic is notable as it sits at the intersection of telecommunications, banking regulation, and development policy in one of Africa's fastest-growing fintech frontiers [\[3\]](#).

The DRC's mobile money ecosystem operates within a multi-agency regulatory environment led by the Banque Centrale du Congo (BCC) for financial services, with ARPTC overseeing telecommunications infrastructure and data protection regimes shaping compliance for PSPs and merchants [\[2\]](#)[\[4\]](#). Market activity is driven by major mobile network operators offering wallet rails—M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money—with ongoing efforts to improve interoperability, agent networks, and cross-border funding in a context of evolving AML/KYC and data privacy rules [\[3\]](#)[\[2\]](#)[\[5\]](#). Regulatory reforms, tax measures, and efforts to modernize digital identity and cross-platform payments have become central to enabling safer, more scalable digital finance in the country [\[3\]](#)[\[6\]](#).

Adoption and usage patterns show a strong urban–rural divide, with agent density, network reliability, and proximity to cash-in/out points shaping uptake. Global benchmarks—such as the growth of mobile money accounts and agent networks in Sub-Saharan Africa—underscore the DRC's potential while highlighting barriers like interoperability and user trust in digital payments [\[7\]](#)[\[8\]](#)[\[9\]](#)[\[10\]](#). Industry analyses emphasize go-to-market strategies that prioritize mobile wallets, local payment methods, lightweight mobile experiences, and blended card–mobile money acceptance to reach a young, rapidly urbanizing population [\[3\]](#)[\[11\]](#).

Despite considerable potential, mobile money in the DRC faces criticisms and risks related to pricing, cross-network transfers, fraud, and data protection. Issues such as SIM swap fraud, variable service reliability, and regulatory unevenness have spurred calls for stronger consumer protection, better fee transparency, and continued interoperability efforts. Projections point to continued growth driven by interoperability, agent expansion, and strategic partnerships—alongside ongoing regulatory maturation and infrastructure improvements—as essential to unlocking broader financial inclusion and development benefits [\[12\]](#)[\[13\]](#)[\[6\]](#)[\[11\]](#).

Overview

Mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) is situated in the early stages of development, despite high mobile phone penetration and growing digital payment activity. Recent observations indicate that financial inclusion remains in a nascent phase, with substantial potential for expansion as mobile money services and agent networks mature [\[14\]](#). Analysts emphasize the importance of tailoring payment acceptance toward mobile wallets and local payment methods to capture the largest share of consumers, reflecting an environment where digital payments are increasingly relevant for merchants [\[3\]](#).

Industry analyses note that the local financial landscape is characterized by evolving dynamics around credit access, banking infrastructure, and the role of mobile money in enabling greater inclusion. This context underscores both opportunities and challenges for scaling mobile money adoption in the country [\[11\]](#). Projections and market intelligence highlight several go-to-market themes, including continued mobile money

expansion, growth of agent networks, rising cross-border e-commerce, advances in digital identity and Know Your Customer (KYC) processes, and regulatory evolution designed to create a more structured and secure digital payments environment [3]. Together, these factors position the DRC as a high-potential frontier market for merchants and fintech providers seeking to reach Africa's next wave of digital consumers, even as infrastructure and regulatory maturity continue to evolve [3].

Background

The Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) has historically exhibited very low formal financial inclusion, with cash remaining the dominant payment method due to limited access to traditional banking services [1]. In this context, mobile money has emerged as a key development, rapidly gaining traction as a means to send and receive funds, pay bills, and make purchases using mobile devices, often leveraging USSD codes or simple apps that are accessible even on basic feature phones [1][15]. Card payments (Visa, Mastercard) exist but remain largely urban and high-income, with adoption still far below cash in the broader population [2].

Regulatory and supervisory frameworks for digital payments are evolving. The Central Bank of Congo (Banque Centrale du Congo, BCC) is the primary regulator overseeing financial services, electronic money institutions (EMIs), payment service providers (PSPs), and foreign exchange activities [2]. The Ministry of Finance provides fiscal oversight, while the ARPTC (Agence de Régulation de la Poste et des Télécommunications du Congo) influences digital communications infrastructure though it does not regulate payments directly [2]. The regulatory environment for mobile money has been accompanied by AML/CFT tightening, including Law No. 18/004 of 2018 on AML and Law No. 18/023 of 2018 on data protection, as well as the CNPDCP (National Data Protection Commission) and related data privacy statutes, which together shape compliance requirements for foreign and domestic merchants [2].

Mobile money adoption in the DRC is supported by the presence of regional and international providers, including M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money, which facilitate transfers, bill payments, and purchases. In addition, MTN Mobile Money is promoted as a platform where users can register and access a range of financial services, with agents available to assist in cash-in and cash-out transactions, reflecting the emphasis on agent networks as the backbone of mobile money in the country [15][16]. Nevertheless, interoperability between different mobile money systems and platforms remains a notable challenge, a common theme in sub-Saharan Africa that can hinder the seamless flow of digital payments [6].

The broader regional context highlights that many countries with notable mobile money growth have pursued regulatory reforms to foster interoperability, consumer protection, and competition, while also balancing AML/CFT and data privacy concerns. This regulatory evolution, combined with ongoing efforts to expand agent networks and liquidity management, underpins the operational dynamics of mobile money in the DRC [6][17]. Overall, mobile money in the DRC operates within a landscape of cash dominance, emerging digital payment options, and evolving regulatory and

compliance requirements designed to expand financial inclusion while managing risk [1][2].

History

Mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) emerged against a backdrop of limited traditional banking penetration, with cash remaining the dominant payment method for many Congolese consumers. Over time, mobile money services gained traction as they offered a feasible alternative for sending and receiving funds, paying bills, and making purchases via basic mobile devices and USSD codes. The leading mobile money providers in the market have included M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money, which leverage accessible platforms to reach a broad user base [3]. Card-based payments, while growing, have remained largely urban and tied to banked segments, with adoption of 3D Secure and other security measures gradually increasing [3].

The regulatory environment for payment services in the DRC is anchored by the Central Bank of Congo (Banque Centrale du Congo, BCC), which oversees banking, electronic money institutions, payment service providers, and foreign exchange activities. The Ministry of Finance also plays a role in fiscal oversight, while the ARPTC (Agence de Régulation de la Poste et des Télécommunications du Congo) influences digital communications infrastructure though it does not regulate payments directly [3]. In addition, data protection regulation has begun to take shape, with Law No. 18/023 of 2018 establishing principles for personal data protection and processing [3].

The payments landscape has seen ongoing collaboration and interoperability efforts, including initiatives led by international firms and local banks. For example, Visa has expanded its presence in the DRC through partnerships that interconnect VisaPay with leading mobile money wallets such as M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money, enabling wallet-funded electronic payments and broader merchant acceptance [18]. This period also witnessed continued expansion of digital payments and fintech-led financial inclusion, as noted in research highlighting the accelerating role of mobile money in West Africa and broader regional contexts [19], [20]. By the mid-2020s, market observers anticipated continued growth in mobile money adoption as infrastructure, regulatory frameworks, and digital literacy gradually improved [3].

Services and ecosystems

In the Democratic Republic of Congo, mobile money services form the backbone of the payments ecosystem, compensating for limited traditional banking penetration and shaping how merchants and consumers transact [3]. Prominent mobile money providers—M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money—enable users to send and receive funds, pay bills, and make purchases via mobile devices, often leveraging USSD codes or simple mobile apps to reach users with basic feature phones [3].

Card payments (Visa and Mastercard) are growing but remain largely urban and income-constrained, with checkout flows typically embedded in merchant websites

or apps and increasing adoption of 3D Secure (3DS) to mitigate fraud. While recurring payments exist, they are more common among urban elites who hold bank accounts [3]. QR code payments are emerging but niche; some merchants link QR codes to wallets to facilitate mobile money acceptance, while invoicing and cash-on-delivery remain common fallbacks amid trust issues and uneven card acceptance [3]. Buy Now, Pay Later (BNPL) and cryptocurrencies have not become mainstream due to regulatory uncertainties and limited infrastructure [3].

From a user experience perspective, the mobile-dominant connectivity environment necessitates mobile-first, lightweight checkout flows with minimal data usage. One-page checkout designs that embed payment forms tend to outperform redirect flows, which can fail on slow connections [3]. For high-risk merchants, local PSP support is limited, making offshore merchant accounts with specialized high-risk processors (e.g., CCBill, PayKings) a common route to global acceptance, albeit with longer onboarding times and higher costs. These arrangements provide fraud tools and regulatory navigation suited to high-risk verticals, enabling international acceptance while remaining compliant with local constraints [3].

The broader payments ecosystem also contends with evolving regulatory and tax considerations. The DRC tax authority is increasingly enforcing withholding tax compliance on digital payments, prompting merchants to engage local tax advisors to optimize their tax position and avoid unexpected deductions [3]. PSPs and merchants must evaluate fees, settlement currencies, and payout timing, as currency controls and tax withholdings can materially impact cash flow and net revenue, underscoring the value of local advisory partnerships for navigation of local requirements [3].

Industry perspectives on the development of mobile money in Africa note the role of mobile operators in expanding financial access and inclusion, with providers increasingly offering adjacent financial services such as credit and savings. As of mid-2024, about 44% of providers reported offering credit services, with savings and insurance available to a lesser but notable share, highlighting the ongoing expansion of the mobile money ecosystem beyond payments [11][21][22]. Commentary from large operators underscores strategic interest in deploying mobile money to rural and low-income populations as a driver of financial inclusion and development goals [23].

Go-to-market strategies for entrants emphasize prioritizing mobile money integrations and cash-on-delivery options, optimizing for mobile-first experiences, French localization, and multi-currency support (CDF and USD). Security considerations include implementing 3DS for card payments and monitoring region-specific fraud patterns such as card testing and SIM swap scams [3]. The overall ecosystem therefore prioritizes accessibility, trust-building through compliant onboarding and security, and alignment with local payment habits to maximize conversions in a challenging but rapidly evolving market [3].

Adoption and usage patterns

Mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) has been influenced by both demand-side and supply-side factors, including agent proximity, urban-rural dynamics, and regulatory or infrastructural conditions. Studies consis-

tently emphasize that the visibility and density of mobile money agents are key determinants of adoption, with closer proximity associated with higher uptake [\[7\]\[8\]](#). In urban contexts, agent networks tend to be more visible and accessible, while rural areas often face coverage and usability challenges [\[24\]\[4\]\[25\]](#).

Global and regional trends provide a backdrop for the DRC's patterns. Based on the Global Findex Database 2021, the share of adults with mobile money accounts rose from about 12% to 33%—a trend that helps contextualize gains in the DRC within broader financial inclusion progress [\[9\]](#). Analyses using two-part models indicate that demographic and economic factors—such as age, education, unemployment, and ownership of bank accounts—explain both the likelihood of adoption and the amount of money sent via mobile money [\[26\]](#). In the DRC, such patterns intersect with urban–rural divides and the quality of agent networks, complicating uniform uptake across the country [\[8\]\[25\]](#).

At the macro level, the global mobile money landscape has shown explosive growth, with over 2 billion registered accounts worldwide in 2024 and roughly 514 million active monthly users, underscoring the sector's momentum and potential for broader adoption in the DRC [\[6\]](#). The expansion of mobile money activity is closely tied to agent networks: in 2024, registered agents reached 28 million globally, with 10 million active monthly, a trend driven largely by Sub-Saharan Africa [\[10\]](#). Dashboards and indicators tracking active accounts, agent density, and transaction volumes illustrate ongoing growth in the region and provide metrics for assessing adoption progress in the DRC over time [\[27\]\[20\]](#).

Rural and urban experiences diverge in adoption and satisfaction. Some evidence suggests that improved mobile money access reduces rural economic activity in certain contexts due to migration incentives, while other findings highlight improvements in remittance efficiency and financial inclusion as agents expand into rural areas [\[20\]\[11\]](#). Across urban settings, exposure to agents, higher connectivity, and greater transaction opportunities contribute to higher adoption rates, though user experiences with agents can vary, including reports of rude or unsatisfactory agent interactions that may influence usage patterns [\[25\]](#).

Key actors

Key regulators, institutions, and industry players shape the mobile money landscape in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC). Regulatory oversight is centered on the Central Bank of Congo (Banque Centrale du Congo, BCC), which governs banking, electronic money institutions (EMIs), payment service providers (PSPs), and foreign exchange activities; the Ministry of Finance also plays a role in fiscal oversight, while the ARPTC (Agence de Régulation de la Poste et des Télécommunications du Congo) influences digital infrastructure though not directly payments regulation [\[5\]](#). In practice, licensing and regulatory evolution in the DRC continue to develop, with supervisory and compliance requirements affecting PSPs and merchants.

Key individuals and researchers contributing to understanding the space include Mugah Michael Sitawa, PhD, a researcher with the Central Africa Observatory on Organised Crime and Violence Project at the Institute for Security Studies, and Major

Beautah Mwanza Suba of the Kenya Defence Forces, who serve as consultants in peace and security [\[28\]](#)[\[12\]](#).

Financial sector players and payment ecosystem participants comprise both local institutions and international PSPs. Local banks such as Rawbank and Trust Merchant Bank provide merchant acquiring services and can be paired with global PSPs like Worldline or Adyen to facilitate card and cross-border payments, reflecting a blended local-global payment strategy [\[3\]](#). The DRC market is dominated by mobile money providers and their ecosystems, with M-Pesa (Vodacom), Airtel Money, and Orange Money serving as major mobile money rails within the country's payment landscape [\[5\]](#). Merchants increasingly pursue hybrid strategies that combine global PSPs with local payment aggregators to accept international cards, mobile money, and local transfers, though this approach can introduce additional technical complexity and regulatory compliance requirements [\[3\]](#).

Academic and industry dialogue highlights the role of mobile money's cash-based economy and the need to focus on prioritized business cases, with potential expansion in the eastern DRC and among the rising middle class in Kinshasa and Katanga identified as strategic targets; these insights are attributed to strategic discussions with industry leaders and researchers [\[8\]](#).

Movement toward mobile money adoption is supported by the regulatory framework for data protection and privacy, which governs personal data handling, cross-border data transfers, and sector-specific security requirements. The CNPDCP oversees data privacy compliance, while cross-border data transfers are restricted absent adequate protections or explicit consent, contributing to the compliance environment for PSPs operating in the DRC [\[29\]](#).

On the ground data and policy context, indicators measuring active mobile money accounts and agent networks capture the accessibility and penetration of mobile money, aligning with broader consumer adoption trends and the ongoing expansion of agent networks to reach rural populations [\[21\]](#). World Bank data cited in related discussions emphasizes the development impact of mobile money on lifting households out of poverty and enabling broader development outcomes, underscoring the importance of key actors in shaping adoption and usage [\[20\]](#).

Market structure and competition

The mobile money market in the Democratic Republic of Congo is still nascent and fragmented, with a mix of local fintech players and mobile network operator-led solutions competing for dominance. The market is currently dominated by the major telecommunications incumbents offering mobile money services, including Vodacom M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money [\[5\]](#).

Market dynamics in late 2024 showed continued strong growth despite a challenging security and macroeconomic environment, signaling a rapidly evolving ecosystem and increasing consumer adoption [\[30\]](#). Within this system, price and interoperability considerations—such as cross-network transfers and government levies—play a crucial role in shaping user behavior and merchant acceptance strategies [\[31\]](#)[\[32\]](#).

Regulatory measures have begun to reshape cost structures. A mobile money levy was introduced in January 2025 under Act No. 25 of 2024 and was subsequently increased in the 2025 amendment, effective 1 January 2026. The levy applies to person-to-person transfers across all providers (MTN, Airtel, Zamtel, and ZedMobile) but does not apply to withdrawals [13]. Fees for on-network and cross-network transfers vary by operator, creating incentives for users to prefer same-network transfers where possible; cross-network transfers incur additional government levies and higher fees, influencing the total cost of remittances and payments [31][32].

Market shares and growth trends in 2025 illustrate ongoing competition among the three leading networks. MTN MoMo and Airtel Money exhibit comparable on-network fee structures, while cross-network transfers carry higher costs and are more sensitive to the governing levy. Industry reporting indicates that Airtel Money pursued substantial fee reductions (including withdrawal and transfer fees) in 2025, contributing to a notable uptick in its active subscriber base, though M-Pesa maintained the largest number of active users at 15.4 million, with Orange Money also expanding rapidly to about 7.7 million customers, highlighting shifting but competitive dynamics among the operators [32][33].

Costs and affordability for everyday users

Mobile money services in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) are accompanied by a range of fees that affect everyday users' willingness and ability to transact. Transactions such as withdrawals, deposits, and transfers between electronic wallets incur charges that can deter frequent use, particularly among low-income or first time users. For example, a document on Airtel Money transaction charges in a neighboring market outlines the various fees for withdrawals, deposits, and transfers [34], while another source summarizes transfer and withdrawal fees for different MoMo services, illustrating how cost structures can add up across common actions [35]. In some contexts, users may also encounter specific transfer charges for moving funds from one wallet to another, further shaping cost perceptions and usage patterns [35].

User experiences with fees can be highly context-dependent. Reports describe scenarios where even small charges or unexpected fees affect user behavior, such as accounts holders who observed surprise fees when wage payments were deposited into their accounts in certain regions [13]. The broader implication is that fee transparency and predictability are critical to trust and sustained engagement with mobile money platforms [13]. Moreover, general market analyses note that fee levels have outsized effects on usage: even modest increases in transfer or withdrawal costs can trigger outsized drops in the number of users or transactions, according to industry observations cited by the GSMA and related analyses [32].

Regulatory and policy considerations can also influence the affordability and availability of mobile money services. In some regions, tax policies and regulatory barriers slow the expansion of mobile money offerings, indirectly affecting price structures and access for consumers [6]. Across markets, interoperability challenges and cross-border or cross-platform transfers can add friction and cost, limiting the full potential of the system for everyday users [6]. Together with concerns about cybersecurity and

fraud, these factors can erode trust and willingness to incur repeated charges [6], [36].

Beyond formal fees, the perceived value of mobile money—paired with the ability to access services without traditional bank accounts—remains a key driver of adoption. When fees are transparent and aligned with users' expectations and incomes, mobile money can provide a cost-effective channel for payments and remittances. However, if charges are opaque or perceived as excessive, users may opt for cash or alternative arrangements, undermining a core objective of financial inclusion in the region [13], [32].

Infrastructure and operational challenges

Efforts to deliver mobile connectivity in remote regions face significant logistical and infrastructural hurdles. Projects such as the AMN-SES collaboration highlight how installation teams must travel to areas with no fibre, no power, and no existing mobile coverage, carving paths through challenging terrain to reach communities previously cut off [37]. Many of these sites rely on solar power and VSAT backhaul, enabling ubiquitous deployment without dependence on established power grids or conventional network infrastructure [37]. The resulting deployments are often solar-powered, remotely managed, and designed to operate in regions where the map effectively ends, underscoring the scale of the access challenge rather than merely the technology [37].

In addition to physical access, carrier and database reliability present operational obstacles. In the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC), for example, the reliability and consistency of telecom operator databases and mobile money registration procedures are variable, complicating service delivery and financial inclusion initiatives [30]. The broader context includes technical and regulatory constraints surrounding mobile money adoption, such as the need to align with local regulatory requirements and ensure secure settlement processes [30].

Digitally accessible services in low-resource settings often rely on non-smartphone technologies. USSD (Unstructured Supplementary Service Data) remains a crucial interface in areas with limited smartphone penetration, offering real-time, text-based menus for financial transactions, government services, and other essential functions even on basic feature phones [38]. Although smartphones are changing usage patterns in urban centers, USSD continues to play a foundational role in reaching populations with constrained infrastructure or affordability constraints, reflecting a diverse and evolving ecosystem for digital access [38][39].

The deployment and operation of USSD- and satellite-enabled networks emphasize a broader design philosophy: build for scarcity and reliability rather than assuming universal, high-bandwidth connectivity. This approach has driven innovations such as multi-technology solutions that support multiple carriers from a single unit, designed to be energy-efficient and to minimize capital expenditure while expanding coverage into hard-to-reach regions [37][38]. However, the ongoing need to manage maintenance, supply chains, and logistical support in remote areas remains a core challenge for scaling up these capabilities [37].

Security, fraud, and consumer protection

The rapid expansion of mobile money services in the Democratic Republic of Congo has coincided with growing exposure to digital fraud, particularly SIM card swapping and phishing schemes. In Goma, residents reported attackers using text messages and calls offering prizes or employment to elicit responses or compromise personal data, with strategies that eventually grant access to victims' accounts [\[12\]](#). SIM hijacking involves impersonating a phone owner to transfer the victim's number to a new SIM, enabling access to text messages, calls, and SMS-based two-factor authentication codes, which criminals can then use to penetrate bank accounts, email, social media, and cryptocurrency wallets [\[12\]](#). The consequences extend beyond individual losses, as fraudsters recontact the victim's network to solicit funds or coercively borrow money, sometimes reaching distant contacts [\[12\]](#).

Regulatory and industry responses are being implemented to curb SIM swap fraud and strengthen consumer protection. At the national level, regulators have introduced stricter SIM registration requirements, including biometric identification for new activations and replacements, in an effort to reduce identity-based manipulation and unauthorized SIM changes [\[12\]](#). Despite these measures, weak oversight of street SIM vendors—who facilitate card swaps by promising quick, low-cost services and sometimes fabricating theft or loss narratives—exacerbates the problem by enabling unverified swaps and reducing the likelihood of identification checks being performed [\[12\]](#). Public awareness efforts emphasize the importance of verifying prize or job offers through registered dealers and avoiding cash requests from unfamiliar numbers without first confirming identity [\[12\]](#).

Beyond SIM-based fraud, the adoption of mobile money in the DRC has driven a broader set of data and privacy concerns. The payments ecosystem involves financial institutions, mobile network operators, and payment service providers (PSPs), each tasked with implementing robust know-your-customer (KYC) checks, anti-money-laundering (AML) measures, and data protection practices. PSP onboarding typically includes thorough KYC verification of merchants, assessment of regulatory compliance, and risk scoring to screen for high-risk activities, such as mismatches between declared business models and actual operations or insufficient processing histories [\[3\]](#). On completion of onboarding, merchants gain access to payment processing tools, but the process may require notarized documents and translations, which can slow deployment but enhance due diligence [\[3\]](#).

Security and data protection standards in the DRC remain evolving, with ongoing efforts to align local practices with international norms. The National Commission for the Protection of Personal Data (CNPDCP) oversees data privacy compliance, and there are rules restricting cross-border transfers of personal data without adequate safeguards or explicit consent [\[3\]](#). The regulatory landscape also encompasses requirements for enhanced security of sensitive data, including financial and biometric information, and mandates for privacy notices and data processing records to be maintained by PSPs and merchants [\[3\]](#). Given the nascent state of data protection

legislation, businesses operating in the DRC are encouraged to monitor regulatory developments and implement best practices aligned with international standards [\[3\]](#).

Impact on consumers and policy implications

Consumers face risks of identity theft, privacy breaches, and emotional distress arising from SIM swaps or data compromises. The ability of criminals to access SMS-based codes allows broad criminal activity, including money laundering or corporate espionage in extreme cases [\[12\]](#).

Effective consumer protection depends on a combination of regulatory enforcement, improved vendor accountability, and public education about safeguarding personal information, verifying legitimate offers, and confirming recipient identities before endorsing financial transfers [\[12\]](#).

For PSPs and merchants, ongoing compliance with KYC/AML requirements, robust data privacy policies, secure data handling, and transparent processing practices are essential to minimize risk and build user trust in mobile money services [\[3\]](#).

Regulatory, compliance, and governance

Regulatory oversight for mobile money and related payment activities in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) involves multiple authorities spanning telecommunications, banking, and data protection. The Agence de Régulation de la Poste et des Télécommunications du Congo (ARPTC) is the regulator of the telecoms sector and is responsible for enforcing applicable laws and regulations within digital communications infrastructure, though it does not regulate payments directly [\[4\]](#). In contrast, the Banque Centrale du Congo (BCC), the Central Bank of Congo, is the primary regulator overseeing financial services and online payments, including licensing for financial activities; ARPTC interacts with digital infrastructure but does not authorize payments itself [\[3\]](#).

Licensing and supervision for payment providers in the DRC derive from a multi-agency framework. The main licensing authorities typically include the BCC; the Ministère des Finances (Ministry of Finance) for fiscal oversight; ARPTC for telecommunications considerations; and the Cellule Nationale de Traitement des Informations Financières (CENTIF) as the financial intelligence unit for AML reporting. Legal pillars include Law No. 18/004 of 2018 on the fight against money laundering and terrorist financing and Law No. 18/023 of 2018 on the protection of personal data, with the Commission Nationale de Protection des Données à Caractère Personnel (CNPDCP) serving as the data protection authority [\[3\]](#). These elements collectively shape the compliance landscape for PSPs (payment service providers) and merchants operating in the DRC.

Data protection and privacy considerations in the DRC are still developing relative to global standards. The data protection framework rests on Law No. 18/023/2018, which establishes basic principles for data collection, processing, and consent, while the CNPDCP oversees data privacy compliance and enforces related regulations. The law also restricts cross-border transfers of personal data unless adequate

protection is ensured or explicit consent is obtained, signaling the emphasis on data localization and protection within the regulatory regime [\[3\]](#).

Anti-money laundering (AML) and know-your-customer (KYC) requirements are enforced to mitigate financial crime. The AML framework, anchored by Law No. 18/004/2018, requires PSPs and banks to perform rigorous onboarding checks, collect official identity documents, verify addresses, and assess beneficial ownership, with ongoing transaction monitoring. PSPs must report suspicious activity to CENTIF, and merchants must provide documentation on ownership, source of funds, and other risk indicators as part of due diligence. This regime aligns with FATF recommendations and underpins the need for robust KYC, AML controls, and transaction monitoring in the DRC [\[3\]](#).

Practical implications for compliance include mandatory KYC for merchants and PSPs, required data privacy protections, and adherence to sector-specific rules. PSPs review merchant websites and product offerings to ensure regulatory compliance, including the presence of essential policies (e.g., refunds, privacy notices) in French or English, and they conduct risk scoring and compliance assessments in line with supervisory expectations (CNPDCP for privacy; CENTIF for AML) [\[3\]](#). Given the evolving nature of data protection and financial oversight, businesses are advised to monitor regulatory developments closely and adopt best practices consistent with international standards.

In sum, regulatory governance for mobile money adoption in the DRC is characterized by a multi-agency structure: ARPTC governs telecommunications infrastructure, the BCC regulates financial services and payments, CENTIF manages AML reporting, and CNPDCP oversees data privacy and protection with supporting laws providing the framework for data handling and cross-border transfers. Merchants and PSPs must implement comprehensive AML/KYC processes, data protection measures, and ongoing regulatory monitoring to ensure compliant operations within the DRC's dynamic regulatory environment [\[4\]](#)[\[3\]](#).

Socioeconomic and development impacts

Mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of Congo has the potential to enhance financial inclusion and poverty reduction by broadening access to formal financial services beyond traditional bank accounts. As mobile money progresses, it can serve as a practical entry point for economically excluded populations, enabling them to save, transact, and access payments more securely and conveniently than cash-based systems [\[19\]](#).

A key development impact of mobile money is its role as a safety net for households facing income shocks. By allowing rapid and low-cost transfers across distances, mobile money helps families weather unexpected expenses, smoothing consumption and reducing the likelihood of downward mobility during crises [\[20\]](#). This buffering effect has been linked to broader improvements in well-being and resilience, particularly for low-income households that rely on remittances and informal transfers [\[20\]](#). In addition, the decreased costs and increased efficiency of sending and receiving money—both domestically and across borders—contribute to more stable household

finances and can support investments in health, education, and productive activities [\[20\]](#).

The broader literature also emphasizes that mobile money can drive development outcomes through improved financial inclusion and access to services. By expanding the reach of financial services, mobile money supports more flexible patterns of work and study, enables households to manage incomes more effectively, and facilitates remittance flows that are often a significant source of funds for families in sub-Saharan Africa [\[19\]\[26\]](#). The adoption process itself is influenced by country-specific characteristics, regulatory environments, and service provision, underscoring the importance of tailored policy and infrastructural support to maximize development benefits in the DRC context [\[40\]](#). Empirical work on mobile money adoption highlights that demographic and economic factors—such as age, education, unemployment, and prior bank account ownership—shape both uptake and usage intensity, informing targeted interventions to broaden impact [\[26\]](#).

Criticisms and risks

Mobile money in the Democratic Republic of Congo has faced a range of criticisms and risks, from pricing and regulatory questions to security and inclusion challenges. Questions emerged around transaction charges, telecom pricing power, interoperability, financial regulation, taxation and digital inclusion, with disputes in some countries over who should bear the costs of USSD-based financial services used by millions of consumers [\[13\]](#). Security has become an increasingly important concern; although USSD avoids some internet-related risks, fraud, SIM swap attacks and social engineering scams continue to affect users as mobile money ecosystems expand [\[13\]](#).

Interoperability between different mobile money providers remains a major hurdle; users often struggle when transferring funds across platforms, limiting the system's full potential [\[6\]](#). Tax policies and regulatory barriers in certain regions can slow expansion, and ongoing fraud and cybersecurity risks threaten user trust in digital financial services [\[6\]\[17\]](#). The technology also exposes substantial differences between global digital experiences, with wealthier countries dominated by app ecosystems while many emerging economies rely on telecom infrastructure as the primary channel for digital participation [\[13\]](#).

Consumer protection and digital literacy are essential complements to financial inclusion efforts. Digital financial services require skills to activate wallets, navigate interfaces, manage passwords, and use authentication services, and risks include lack of fee transparency, aggressive marketing, poor dispute resolution, data or identity theft, and app fraud. These challenges are not new to traditional banking but are amplified by the reach and convenience of mobile money, underscoring the need for strong consumer protections and education [\[41\]](#).

Reliance on agent networks brings its own risks, including liquidity management and trust dynamics. Agents are often trusted local figures, yet the system's health depends on liquidity and broader banking system support, which can affect service reliability and access [\[17\]\[23\]](#). In addition, there are real-world incidents of scams and

fraud affecting users, such as a notable in-country case in 2018 where individuals were deceived by online schemes, highlighting vulnerabilities in consumer protection in contexts with large unbanked populations [\[42\]](#).

Persistent barriers to adoption also include gender disparities; across twelve countries surveyed, eight show a continuing gender gap in mobile money ownership, with limited awareness and low digital financial literacy particularly affecting women [\[19\]](#). Collectively, these criticisms and risks illustrate the multifaceted challenges facing the broader adoption and trust of mobile money in the Democratic Republic of Congo and similar markets.

Initiatives and programs

Efforts to expand and improve mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of Congo have often occurred within broader humanitarian and development programming, emphasizing better targeting, oversight, and resilience. In rapid-response and aid-delivery contexts, new data-collection systems have been introduced to reduce manipulation of beneficiary information, with UNICEF and partner agencies increasing oversight and revamping registration questionnaires to improve accuracy and eligibility determinations [\[43\]](#). These measures aim to strengthen the integrity of cash transfer and other mobile-enabled assistance in volatile settings such as conflict-affected areas [\[43\]](#).

Humanitarian actors have also sought to improve deployment speed and transparency in response programmes. Since 2017, UNICEF and other partners have pushed for faster interventions in rapid-response mechanisms, with concerns that emphasis on speed can heighten risk if data systems and recruitment controls are weak; reforms have included tighter beneficiary verification and more robust data-management practices to mitigate fraud and misallocation [\[43\]](#). Aid organizations have noted vulnerabilities in field operations—such as manipulation of beneficiary registries, inadequate reference checks for new staff, and a lack of cross-organizational blacklists—that can undermine cash-transfer programmes and other mobile money-based support unless properly addressed [\[43\]](#).

Beyond targeting and safeguards, digital literacy and user-friendly design are recognized as essential components of expanding mobile money adoption. Studies and industry analyses emphasize that low digital financial literacy remains a major barrier to uptake, and that providers have responded by launching digital literacy initiatives to accompany service provision, aiming to close knowledge gaps and improve user confidence across genders and age groups [\[33\]](#). This aligns with broader findings that improving financial inclusion hinges not only on product provision but also on consumer education and supportive regulatory environments [\[38\]](#).

In the wider regional context, the relationship between financial inclusion, mobile money adoption, and development underscores that expanding access to mobile financial services can help move people beyond subsistence. Evidence from global studies suggests that mobile money can reduce poverty and contribute to broader development when complemented by literacy, appropriate regulation, and reliable service delivery, factors that are also relevant to implementation in the DRC [\[20\]](#)[\[38\]](#).

Metrics and measurement

Efforts to quantify mobile money adoption in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) typically rely on a set of core indicators that capture both the breadth and the depth of usage. Adoption is commonly described by the number of mobile money accounts per adult, referred to as the adult penetration rate, while activity focuses on the rate of usage and the frequency of transactions. In practice, researchers and organizations measure three principal dimensions: adoption, activity, and access to services, using metrics such as the total accounts, the number of active accounts, and the extent of agent networks as proxies for ecosystem maturity [\[21\]\[7\]](#).

One widely used data source for measuring adoption and usage is the International Monetary Fund's Financial Access Survey, which tracks metrics such as the active number of mobile money accounts. In Congo, the IMF data series CODFCMAANUM provides time series for the active mobile money user base, and these data are typically accessed through repositories such as FRED (Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis) with accompanying notes on data licensing and publication practices [\[44\]](#). Observations and notes accompanying these data emphasize that the figures are presented as annual, non-seasonally adjusted counts and that the data are subject to copyright and revision, requiring review of the series notes before sharing or reuse [\[44\]](#).

Beyond raw account counts, analyses may employ econometric models to understand determinants of adoption. Studies have used regression approaches to quantify the impact of variables such as country characteristics, regulatory environments, and service provision on mobile money adoption, with specific attention to how these determinants influence uptake in different contexts (including Egypt as a comparative reference) [\[40\]](#). In addition, there is a recognition that agent proximity and the density of agents can significantly affect adoption rates; proximity to agents is repeatedly identified as a decisive factor for expanding access in many settings [\[7\]](#).

Qualitative and data-pipeline considerations also shape measurement. Data and visualizations on global platforms (e.g., dashboards that display metrics on accounts, agents, and usage) illustrate growth trajectories and help normalize cross-country comparisons, while noting that datasets can be drawn from multiple providers and require standardization and metadata alignment for comparability [\[27\]\[11\]\[45\]](#). Platforms and datasets from international organizations and research collaborations emphasize a comprehensive view of financial access, including indicators such as ownership levels, usage intensity, and agent network reach, to capture the multi-faceted nature of mobile money adoption in Congo and similar markets [\[46\]](#).

In practice, the measurement framework often integrates:

Adoption: number of mobile money accounts per adult (adult penetration rate) [\[21\]](#).

Activity: measures such as the share of the adult population who use mobile money, transaction frequency, and transaction value (as components of usage) [\[21\]](#).

Access/Proximity: density and reach of mobile money agents and the ease of access to basic financial services via mobile channels (e.g., USSD/USSD-like interfaces) in rural and underserved areas [\[7\]\[46\]](#).

Data sources and governance: IMF Financial Access Survey series data (e.g., CODFCMAANUM for Congo), with caveats about annual frequency, copyright, and revisions [\[44\]](#).

Future prospects

The Democratic Republic of the Congo stands as a high-potential frontier for mobile money adoption, with rapid mobile penetration and fintech-led financial inclusion driving early momentum in digital payments. While infrastructure and regulatory frameworks are still maturing, the strong base of mobile subscribers and active fintech activity create a favorable environment for continued growth in digital wallets, mobile money transfers, and connected payment experiences [\[3\]\[47\]](#).

Interoperability remains a central challenge that will shape the pace of adoption. Fragmentation across mobile money providers and platforms currently restricts cross-wallet transfers and full ecosystem liquidity, limiting the ability of users to move funds seamlessly. Addressing interoperability—alongside broader regulatory clarity and consumer trust—will be critical to unlocking wider user uptake and merchant acceptance [\[47\]](#).

Merchant adoption strategies are increasingly incorporating a mix of payment modalities beyond traditional card acceptance. QR code payments and USSD-based options are highlighted as practical, lightweight channels that work well on low-bandwidth connections, while mobile wallets continue to be the dominant channel for many consumers. In response, providers and merchants are likely to pursue blended solutions that combine mobile money wallets, card acceptance, QR/USSD payments, and eventually more interoperable rails to maximize reach [\[3\]](#).

Strategic partnerships and interoperability initiatives are already propelling growth. For example, Visa's collaboration with Onafriq to interconnect VisaPay with major mobile money wallets (M-Pesa, Airtel Money, and Orange Money) demonstrates how cross-network interoperability can expand digital payment acceptance and funding options for a broader user base. Such collaborations are expected to contribute to the expansion of digital transactions in the DRC, with digital payments projected to rise toward several billions of dollars in the near term [\[11\]](#). The GSMA projects digital transaction value reaching approximately \$3.85 billion in 2025, reinforcing the scale potential for mobile money ecosystems when supported by interoperable, user-friendly services [\[11\]](#).

Regulatory support and government-led digital economy initiatives are evolving in ways that can accelerate adoption. As policy frameworks mature and payment infrastructure is modernized, formalizing digital finance channels and reducing compliance barriers will be essential to sustain growth and foster trust among users and merchants alike [\[3\]](#).

In sum, the outlook for mobile money adoption in the DRC is optimistic but contingent on achieving greater interoperability, continued mobile-centric infrastructure development, and strategic partnerships that expand access and simplify digital payments for the broad and youthful population driving demand [\[3\]\[47\]\[11\]](#).

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